

Historic Wiley

From the town history, map sites 23–25.
Photographs colorized and enhanced
from the original plates.

Wiley (#23 on the map) was incorporated in 1907 by the Big Bend Town Company, named for W.M. Wiley, president of the Holly Sugar Company, and built on a plan of wide streets that still shapes the town today.

The Town of Wiley was incorporated in 1907 by the Big Bend Town Company, and the big push on building and expansion came just at the turn of the century. Many farms were in operation in the area and the Fort Lyon Canal water brought progress to the area’s farmers and ranchers. A branch of the Santa Fe Railroad was built through the heart of the agricultural land and was to be known as the Arkansas Valley Line, or “A.V.”

Actually, the need for a town arose when home and farm items needed by area residents were sought locally. Also, with business coming into the area, crops such as corn, alfalfa, sugar beets, wheat and livestock could be marketed. The Big Bend Town Company purchased 80 acres of land from J.F. Rowe and a good city plan was made with wide streets part of the original plan. The commercial section for an elevator and depot was near the railroad tracks; about two blocks north of this area more space was allocated for businesses, grocery stores, dry goods stores, machinery shops, drugstores, hardware and lumber firms and hotels.

Edward Pierson, local contractor and member of the Town Company, with his cement block machine began making 100 blocks per day in forms, removing them the next day to make way for more. The rapidly constructed buildings were occupied as fast as they were completed. Several houses were also built of these bricks, four of which still remain. The first merchants were J.N. Hudson, H.S. Parker, O.B. Yoeman and W.H. Blosser, who was also the first postmaster in 1908.

The opera house was erected of these familiar blocks on ground where the modern post office building now stands. Traveling shows and melodramas played in Wiley and the opera house was the cultural center for the town. The ground floor was occupied by the Hadley Mercantile Company managed by F.H. Tanner. The upper floor provided, in addition to space for the arts, space for professional offices—doctor, modiste, etc. To the west of this building, toward what was McCue Lumber Company but is now Wiley Supply Company, was a series of cement block buildings housing a shoe and harness shop, a confectionery store, a café and, at one time, the post office. Medicine shows and chautauqua brought in more entertainment to Wiley. At a later date a movie theatre was housed in the ground floor of the opera house.



THE WILEY OPERA HOUSE · EQUITY BUILDING · NO. 23-2 ON MAP



WILEY’S MAIN STREET

The first school in Wiley was built on Main Street with blocks from Mr. Pierson’s mighty machine and was ready for occupancy in 1907; the first high school class graduated in 1912. Silverdale, three miles north of Wiley, was the first “country school” to consolidate with the Wiley school and the first in Colorado to consolidate with any school. A hot lunch program was another “first” in the state for the Wiley school. Other schools to consolidate with Wiley were East and West Enterprize, East and West Riverview, Big Bend, Crescent, Columbine and Cactus View.

The year 1908 brought a severe epidemic of typhoid fever which swept the whole area. It was soon realized that cisterns being used, supposedly purified with a filtering system, must go. The town built the first water system in 1910, using water from a deep well on Santa Fe property. Later a well with a water tower was located on Gordan Street.



WILEY CREAMERY AND CHEESE FACTORY, LATER TURKEY PLANT · NO. 23-4 ON MAP

Other early businesses were: a grain elevator, a weekly newspaper, a sugar beet dump, a pool hall, a drug store complete with pharmacist, a milliner’s shop, hotels, garages and gas stations. There was also a theater with “talkies” which were the first in this area. A hotel just east of the bank was destroyed by fire. Hotel rooms were once available above the community building. A jail stood on the site of the present athletic field and legends tell of Halloween pranksters spending the night there after an evening of “fun.” Of course, an occasional lawbreaker did have to stay there, too. There were no saloons in the town, however, at that time.

“Wiley Sugar Beet Day” was well-known all over the area and was a yearly occasion for fun for the family. There was a fair each time and these events, which began in 1920, continued

Mr. Lindstrom built and operated the blacksmith shop in a building which is now a part of the Arkansas Valley Pellet Mill. A livery stable was located just west of the business district with horses and carriages for hire. Other buildings, of red brick, were made at a later date on the east side of what is now Main Street in Wiley.

A brick plant was built on land where the Lamle farm is now located, but the quality of bricks turned out was poor and the plant was soon abandoned. The I.O.O.F. Building, still standing, was constructed in 1910, and the Parker Mercantile Company general store occupied the ground floor. The brick used for this building was shipped in by rail.

In 1908 the Methodist Episcopal Church was constructed of the concrete block with red beading between blocks to add interest to the structure. The church was first organized as the Fairview M.E. Church in 1895 and held services in a small rock church beside the Wiley cemetery. The Church of the Brethren was constructed of red brick during 1912–1913 and the Church of God was built in 1920.

Also in 1908 came The Denver Alfalfa Milling Company which set up an operation near Wiley which was claimed to be the largest hay mill in the entire U.S. at that time. Houses of various types and sizes soon followed in the busy town.

The State Bank of Wiley was organized in 1907 by H.G. Lamson and contributed to the stabilization of the community’s financial basis. Mr. Lamson was also the first mayor of Wiley. The bank building at the present location was built in 1908; previous to that time banking services were conducted from the McCue Lumber Yard. Telephone service was installed in the area before the town even existed. Mountain States Telephone and Telegraph Company took over in 1912 and rebuilt the system with a central office located at Third and Gordon Streets. The office was moved and dial service was installed in 1939, the second office in Colorado to go to dial service.

A creamery and cheese factory was built about 1915. After a condensary was built in Lamar, ten miles south, the creamery and cheese building was used for a pickle factory in 1925 and later for a turkey processing plant which prospered several years.



WILEY LIVERY AND FEED YARD

through the late 1930’s. Wiley has always been a town of great pride, keeping the streets and alleys clean, houses painted, lawns green, school progressive. The basic resource of the Wiley area has been its people, the farmers using progressive methods and business people providing needed goods and superior services. Many families, such as Burke, Cline, Downing, Esgar, Reyher, Tempel, Ullom and others, continue to carry on the fine traditions established by their forefathers. Wiley is proud to be part of the U.S. Bicentennial and Colorado Centennial, and has been proclaimed a Bicentennial City, receiving an award from Washington, D.C. signed by President Gerald Ford.

BIG BEND

#24 ON MAP

The town of Big Bend is two miles west of here. It was a community before Wiley was established. One unusual thing was that a group of men in this community formed the Big Bend town company and built Wiley in one year, 1906. They laid out the town on 80 acres, put in the streets, curb and gutter out of stone, built some business places and had the present town of Wiley going. Big Bend is a feed lot and a store now but it is the site of many things planned and carried out.

KOEN RANCH (WEST)

#25 ON MAP

The Koen Ranch was the headquarters for the family. They obtained the water rights for, and built the Amity Irrigation Canal System. The Koen Brothers obtained the water appropriation from the State of Colorado in 1886. The stone on the barn says 1888. The big barn was built to care for the many horses needed to dig the irrigation canal. In 1908 they were growing sugar beets on this farm. This is still a 640 acre farm, half of it irrigated and half river pasture.

INDIAN CLAIM

#25-1 ON MAP

The Indian Claim on which this farm is located and for several miles to the west was signed by President Abraham Lincoln on August 6, 1861. It is said that this treaty was made with the tribes who were involved in the Sand Creek Massacre. This was to give the Arapahoes and Cheyennes ownership of this land to settle and make a living on under private ownership. Each member of the tribes was to receive 40 acres.